building who we had befriended, and I used to go to their house to play with their son. The father had to go back to Israel when the war broke out and, of course, the mother was worried. I don't remember any of their names, except that we were quite good friends. The upshot of this was that the Suez Canal had been closed by Egypt (and remained closed till 1975), and so we had to come back by air. That was my first experience of air travel and of Air India. My best friend in Paris was Michel Tavard, and I wrote to him on the Air India postcard but it never got sent. I still have that postcard, and that is perhaps why I still remember his name. I wonder where all my French friends are now and what became of them. *Que sera sera*.

On our return to India, my father was posted at the Base Repair Depot in Chandigarh. We children though, were admitted as boarders to schools in Pune, our hometown. My sister went to Saint Mary's Girls School, and my brother and I to Bishop's Boys School. Now it was time for reverse adjustment, which was even more difficult. In France, we were '*Indiens*', in Bishop's, we were known as 'Frenchie'. When we had gone to France, I was still in pre-school, on my return, I was in the 4th Standard. In France, we had learnt and spoken only French outside our home, and Marathi among ourselves for day-to-day stuff. But we had no formal learning in the language. On my return to India, I knew no English at all and only a smattering of Marathi. So, once again, I found myself in a similar position of not being able to communicate with my teachers or classmates. It goes to my parents' credit though, that they had anticipated this situation. Towards the fag end of our stay in Paris, they engaged a tutor to teach us Hindi; in my case, starting from '*ka, kha, ga*'. Since the medium of instruction at Bishop's was English, I soon became proficient in English and it became my primary language, while Hindi remained a

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